Performance Task: PLC Planning Partner

Overview

This performance task is designed to assess two core competencies:

1. **Synthesis and prototyping under ambiguity.** Turning messy, incomplete input into a tangible artifact.
2. **Design judgment and product leadership.** Identifying and navigating constraints, recommending a path, naming tradeoffs, and pushing past the original vision rather than executing it as given.

The task has two parts: the initial task will be done at-home, followed by a 60-minute interview where we build on what you prepared. This packet contains an overview of the process, the scenario, and some notes on logistics.

What to Expect

Before the interview. Read the scenario attached and come with a wireframe or working design idea for the core planning experience. Present it in whatever format works best for you: sketches, annotated screens, a clickable prototype, or a short walkthrough. We expect preparation to take no more than 2 hours.

During the interview. You'll present your design and the choices behind it. After you share your initial design, we'll share a new constraint or complication. You'll have 20 minutes to decide how to prioritize it and incorporate it into your design, or to explain why parts of your original design should hold. There's no single right answer; we want to see how you reason through the tradeoff.

The Scenario

Last month, our Innovation team hosted a two-day jam session where staff sketched and prototyped ideas for AI tools in education. Two of your colleagues, Danika and Shawn, came out of it with a concept they want to pitch for a real pilot with a partner school district this fall.

They've asked you, as design lead, to help turn their first-pass thinking into a prototype that makes the pitch concrete. What follows is what they've shared with you. It's a work in progress, so expect gaps and some ideas that pull against each other.

Background

In many schools, teachers meet regularly in small groups called professional learning communities (PLCs). Together they plan upcoming lessons, look at student work, and get better at teaching. Each PLC has a leader who plans what the group does in each meeting. Math PLCs in our partner district meet weekly or every other week for 45 to 60 minutes.

What Danika and Shawn Shared

Problem statement. Even well-run PLCs, where teachers meet consistently and plan carefully, don't reliably change what happens in classrooms. Danika and Shawn think one reason is that most PLC meetings aren't grounded in evidence. They focus on two sources:

1. **Student progress data:** short end-of-lesson checks and unit assessments that show what students actually understand.
2. **Instructional data:** notes from classroom observations that show what teaching actually looks like.

By looking closely at both, teachers can spot common student mistakes, connect them to how lessons are taught, and agree on what to teach differently. PLC leaders rarely have the time or support to pull this evidence together and turn it into a plan. So meetings either skip the data or become a quick scan of scores with no clear next step.

Note: The district uses a digital math curriculum. Students complete short end-of-lesson checks (called cool-downs) and unit assessments online, so results are available right away. A coach or school leader also observes each teacher about once a quarter and records notes on their teaching. The data exists; it's just rarely used when PLCs plan.

Their theory. If PLCs regularly grounded their planning in student progress and instructional data, their plans would be more targeted and would have more impact on teaching and learning.

Concept. An AI planning partner that helps a PLC leader prepare a meeting in 20 to 40 minutes. It does two jobs:

1. Helps the leader visualize and interpret student and instructional data, so patterns are easy to see.
2. Helps the leader plan the meeting around what the data shows: the agenda, slides, and activities.

Core principle: do with, never do for. The tool carries the workload, but the leader does the thinking. It tests the leader's ideas rather than supplying them, and it never hands over a finished plan the leader didn't shape.

Target users. PLC leaders, who are usually instructional coaches, assistant principals, or teachers. Leaders differ in three ways that matter for design, and these combine:

1. **One grade or several.** Some leaders run a single-grade PLC and plan around one lesson's data. Others span several grades, such as 3rd through 5th, and must find a common thread across three sets of lessons and results so the meeting isn't three separate conversations.
2. **Comfort with data.** Some leaders read assessment results confidently. Others find score reports intimidating or aren't sure which patterns matter.
3. **Comfort with AI.** Some leaders use AI daily. Others rarely do and may need step-by-step guidance.

First-pass workflow. Their early prototype is a chatbot.

1. The leader opens the tool and names the PLC focus (planning or looking at student work).
2. The tool pulls the relevant lessons, recent student results, and the latest observation notes.
3. The tool shows the data visually, such as which problems students missed most and how results differ across classes.
4. The leader names what they think the data shows and what to focus on, and the tool tests their reasoning.
5. The leader builds the meeting with the tool's support: an agenda, slides, and activities targeted to that focus.

6. The leader leaves with a plan and a way to check, in the next round of data, whether teaching changed.

Open questions and aspirations.

1. **Workspace design.** Right now, the flow is chat-based and the data visualizations produced within a chat don't execute automatically, and it's annoying to keep scrolling up. How would the conversation and the data share the workspace?
2. **How much data to show?** A full dashboard could let the leader explore, but it can overwhelm someone with only 20 minutes to spare. A few highlighted patterns are faster, but the leader may never look closely enough to own the conclusion.
3. **Fresh and stale data.** Student results update daily, but observations happen once a quarter. Danika and Shawn aren't sure how to show the two together without older observation notes misleading the plan.

What good looks like. The leader walks into the meeting with a plan grounded in specific evidence they can explain in their own words. The plan targets one concrete change in teaching, and the next round of data shows whether it worked.

Your Task

Prototype the core planning experience Danika and Shawn should pitch. You can't resolve every open question or serve every user equally in one pass, so prioritize. Be ready to explain which questions you took a position on, which users you designed for first, and why.

Bring your wireframe or working design idea to the interview, in whatever format works best for you. We're interested in your reasoning and tradeoffs, not visual polish.

You are free to make assumptions as needed where you are missing context or data that might influence your design. Please track & be prepared to share your assumptions during the interview.

Logistics

- **Tools.** Use whatever you work best in: Figma, code, AI prototyping tools. Free tiers are sufficient, and you'll share your screen during the interview.
- **Your work.** Everything in this packet is fictional, so it's safe to use in any account. Your work stays yours. We'll only ask for a link or screenshots afterward.
- **Accommodations.** If anything about this format would make it harder for you to show your best thinking, let us know at talent@leadingeducators.org and we'll adjust.